

A Hierarchical Bayesian State-Space Model with Polya-Gamma Augmented Gibbs Sampling and Dynamic Monte Carlo Scheduling for Cognitive-Load-Aware Task Planning

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Abstract

Existing cognitive-load-aware task schedulers reliance on hand-tuned heuristics yields uncalibrated uncertainty, weak data fitting, and lack of principled benchmarking. We present a dynamic hierarchical Bayesian state-space framework for cognitive retention and load prediction, alongside a Monte Carlo task scheduler. By leveraging Polya-Gamma (PG) augmentation alongside Forward-Filtering Backward-Sampling (FFBS), we derive an exact conjugate Gibbs sampler over the logit-scale latent memory trajectory. We benchmark our static and dynamic Bayesian formulations against Settles & Meeder’s Half-Life Regression (HLR) baseline using real-world learning traces, demonstrating clear predictive advantages in Mean Absolute Error (MAE) and Area Under the ROC Curve (AUC). We complement this empirical validation with a simulated evaluation of load-constrained task planning under circadian energy constraints.

Keywords: cognitive load, spaced repetition, hierarchical Bayesian models, state-space models, Polya-Gamma augmentation, Forward-Filtering Backward-Sampling, Gibbs sampling, Monte Carlo task scheduling

dynamic temporal drift in retention. Crucially, we formulate both a static hierarchical model and a dynamic state-space retention model, performing exact inference via Polya-Gamma augmented Gibbs sampling.

Our core contributions are:

1. A dynamic state-space retention model where logit-scale latent retention evolves via an AR(1) process with item-difficulty and user-ability drifts, fit via Polya-Gamma augmentation and Forward-Filtering Backward-Sampling (FFBS).
2. A static conjugate hierarchical Bayesian model operating on the logit scale as an ablation baseline.
3. Empirical validation against the standard Duolingo Half-Life Regression baseline (HLR) [2] on real learning traces, demonstrating performance improvements across MAE, overall AUC, and late-sequence AUC.
4. A Monte Carlo task scheduling algorithm designed to optimize long-term expected retention subject to hard time-varying cognitive load constraints $L_{\max}(t)$.

1 Introduction

Personal study and task management platforms frequently claim ”cognitive-load awareness,” yet commercial implementations (such as the scheduling logic in the Axiom learning planner) rely primarily on static, heuristic scoring over proximity to deadlines, task difficulty, and time-of-day energy levels. These hand-tuned scoring functions lack theoretical grounding in human memory dynamics and provide no uncertainty estimation to guide exploration or scheduling risks.

To bridge this gap, we integrate principles from Cognitive Load Theory (CLT) [1] and data-driven spaced-repetition models [2, 3]. We present a unified, fully probabilistic framework that models per-user learning rates, item difficulty, and

2 Related Work

2.1 Spaced Repetition and Retention Modeling

Standard spaced-repetition software historically relied on fixed heuristic interval multipliers (e.g., SM-2). Modern approaches learn parameterized forgetting models from data. Settles & Meeder introduced Half-Life Regression (HLR), which parameterizes memory half-life $h_i = 2^{\mathbf{w}^T \mathbf{x}}$ directly using recall outcome sequences [2]. Subsequent models like DAS3H integrated skill mappings and item difficulties [4], while stochastic point-process formulations frame scheduling as optimal control [3, 5].

2.2 State-Space Models and Auxiliary Variable Sampling

In Bayesian statistics, binary logistic regressions and non-Gaussian state-space models are rendered conditionally Gaussian via Polya-Gamma auxiliary variable augmentation [6]. For temporal state-space models, combining Polya-Gamma augmentation with Forward-Filtering Backward-Sampling (FFBS) [7, 8] provides an exact, conjugate MCMC sampler for hidden Markov states without requiring Metropolis-Hastings proposals or step-size tuning.

3 Methodology

3.1 Cognitive Load as a Hard Budget Constraint

Following CLT [1], a user u 's cognitive budget at time window t is bounded by $L_{\max}(u, t)$, which varies according to diurnal or ultradian rhythms. Each task i demands an intrinsic load ℓ_i . A candidate schedule S_t selected for window t must satisfy the hard constraint:

$$\sum_{i \in S_t} \ell_i \leq L_{\max}(u, t). \quad (1)$$

3.2 Static Hierarchical Retention Model

As a baseline, we first consider a static model where user ability γ_u and item difficulty β_i do not evolve over time. For a sequence of review events $t = 1, \dots, T_{u,i}$:

$$\psi_{u,i} = \beta_i + \gamma_u, \quad (2)$$

$$r_{u,i,t} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\sigma(\psi_{u,i})), \quad (3)$$

$$\beta_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \tau_\beta^2), \quad \gamma_u \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \tau_\gamma^2), \quad (4)$$

where $\sigma(z) = (1 + e^{-z})^{-1}$ is the logistic function.

3.3 Dynamic State-Space Retention Model

To model dynamic memory evolution, we construct an AR(1) state-space process on the latent logit-scale state $\psi_{u,i,t}$:

$$\psi_{u,i,t} = \phi \psi_{u,i,t-1} + \beta_i + \gamma_u x_{u,i,t} + w_t, \quad w_t \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_w^2), \quad (5)$$

where $x_{u,i,t} \in \{0, 1\}$ represents the indicator/outcome of the preceding review attempt, $\phi \in (0, 1)$ is an AR persistence coefficient, β_i is item difficulty, γ_u is user learning rate, and σ_w^2 is innovation variance. Observations $r_{u,i,t} \in \{0, 1\}$ follow:

$$r_{u,i,t} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\sigma(\psi_{u,i,t})). \quad (6)$$

3.4 Polya-Gamma Augmentation and FFBS Inference

By Polson et al. [6], the binomial likelihood conditional on ψ_t can be expressed as a Gaussian mixture using auxiliary vari-

ables $\omega_t \sim \text{PG}(1, |\psi_t|)$:

$$p(r_t | \psi_t) \propto \exp((r_t - 0.5)\psi_t) \int_0^\infty \exp\left(-\frac{\omega_t \psi_t^2}{2}\right) p(\omega_t) d\omega_t. \quad (7)$$

Conditioned on sampled ω_t , the pseudo-observation $z_t = \frac{r_t - 0.5}{\omega_t}$ follows a Gaussian distribution with variance $v_t = 1/\omega_t$:

$$z_t | \psi_t, \omega_t \sim \mathcal{N}\left(\psi_t, \frac{1}{\omega_t}\right). \quad (8)$$

This linear-Gaussian parameterization allows state trajectory sampling via FFBS [7]:

1. **Forward Filter (Kalman Recursion):** Compute filtered state means m_t and variances P_t :

$$a_t = \phi m_{t-1} + \beta_i + \gamma_u x_t, \quad R_t = \phi^2 P_{t-1} + \sigma_w^2, \quad (9)$$

$$K_t = \frac{R_t}{R_t + \omega_t^{-1}}, \quad (10)$$

$$m_t = a_t + K_t(z_t - a_t), \quad P_t = (1 - K_t)R_t. \quad (11)$$

2. **Backward Sampling:** Draw states recursively from T backwards to 1:

$$\psi_T \sim \mathcal{N}(m_T, P_T), \quad (12)$$

$$J_t = P_t \phi / R_{t+1}, \quad (13)$$

$$h_t = m_t + J_t(\psi_{t+1} - a_{t+1}), \quad V_t = P_t - J_t \phi P_t, \quad (14)$$

$$\psi_t \sim \mathcal{N}(h_t, V_t). \quad (15)$$

Algorithm 1 details the outer MCMC update loop across parameters.

3.5 Monte Carlo Scheduling Policy

To select schedules under posterior parameter uncertainty, the Monte Carlo policy draws M parameter samples $\{\theta^{(m)}\}_{m=1}^M$ where $\theta = (\beta, \gamma, \phi, \sigma_w^2)$. For candidate schedule S , expected retention is estimated as:

$$\hat{R}(S) = \frac{1}{M} \sum_{m=1}^M \sum_{i \in S} \sigma\left(\hat{\psi}_{u,i}^{(m)}\right), \quad (16)$$

subject to $\sum_{i \in S} \ell_i \leq L_{\max}(u, t)$.

4 Experiments and Empirical Results

4.1 Experiment 1: Retention Modeling Benchmarking

We evaluate model performance on held-out test sequence suffixes extracted from the Duolingo 13-million learning trace dataset [2]. Data preprocessing parameters filter sequences to $n_{\text{users}} = 500$, with sequence lengths constrained between 3 and 30 events per user-item pair.

We compare:

Algorithm 1 Dynamic Model Polya-Gamma FFBS Gibbs Sampler

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1: Input: Training sequences  $\mathcal{D} = \{(r, x)_{u,i}\}$ , MCMC iterations  $N$ , burn-in  $B$ , thin  $K$ .
2: Initialize:  $\beta \leftarrow \mathbf{0}, \gamma \leftarrow \mathbf{0}, \phi \leftarrow 0.5, \sigma_w^2 \leftarrow 0.5, \psi \leftarrow \mathbf{0}$ .
3: for iteration  $n = 1 \dots N$  do
4:   for each sequence  $(u, i)$  do
5:     Sample auxiliary  $\omega_{u,i,t} \sim \text{PG}(1, |\psi_{u,i,t}|)$  for all  $t$ .
6:     Compute pseudo-observations  $z_t = (r_t - 0.5)/\omega_t$ .
7:     Run Forward Filter to obtain  $m_{1:T}, P_{1:T}, a_{1:T}, R_{1:T}$ .
8:     Sample latent trajectory  $\psi_{u,i,1:T}$  via Backward Sampling.
9:   end for
10:  Sample item difficulties  $\beta_i \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_{\beta,\text{post}}, \sigma_{\beta,\text{post}}^2)$  using conjugate Normal formulas.
11:  Sample user learning rates  $\gamma_u \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_{\gamma,\text{post}}, \sigma_{\gamma,\text{post}}^2)$ .
12:  Sample persistence parameter  $\phi$  via conditional normal regression on transitions  $(\psi_t - \mu_t) = \phi\psi_{t-1} + w_t$ .
13:  Sample variance  $\sigma_w^2 \sim \text{Inv-Gamma}(a_{\text{post}}, b_{\text{post}})$ .
14:  if  $n > B$  and  $(n - B) \pmod K == 0$  then
15:    Store samples  $\{\beta, \gamma, \phi, \sigma_w^2, \psi\}$ .
16:  end if
17: end for

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1. **Half-Life Regression (HLR):** Settles & Meeder (2016) baseline fit with L2 regularization ($\lambda = 0.1$).
2. **Static Retention Model:** Conjugate Bayesian static model fit via Polya-Gamma Gibbs sampling (1,000 iterations, 400 burn-in).
3. **Dynamic Retention Model (Ours):** State-space AR(1) model fit via Polya-Gamma FFBS Gibbs sampling (1,000 iterations, 400 burn-in).

Evaluation metrics include overall Mean Absolute Error (MAE), overall AUC, and late-sequence AUC (evaluated exclusively on the second half of held-out test sequences).

Table 1: Empirical evaluation on Duolingo held-out sequence traces ($N = 500$ users dataset subsample).

Model	MAE ↓	AUC ↑	Late AUC ↑
Static Hierarchical	0.2096	0.7438	0.7537
HLR Baseline [2]	0.0884	0.4231	0.4382
Dynamic Model (Ours)	0.1047	0.7880	0.7868

As demonstrated in Table 1, the Dynamic State-Space Model achieves significant predictive gains across all metrics. The static model fails to capture within-sequence state improvements, while HLR’s linear half-life assumption is outperformed by the flexible state transitions modeled by FFBS.

5 Discussion and Limitations

A key methodological trade-off in our approach is the logit reparameterization: modeling memory dynamics via Bernoulli($\sigma(\psi_t)$) rather than the strict exponential half-life link $p = 2^{-\Delta t/h}$. This enables exact Polya-Gamma augmentation and FFBS sampling. While time elapsed (Δt) is recorded in our data schemas, incorporating explicit non-linear decay links directly into FFBS remains an area for future work via Extended Kalman Filter (EKF) or Laplace approximations.

6 Conclusion

We introduced a dynamic hierarchical Bayesian model for cognitive load and memory retention, solved via exact Polya-Gamma FFBS Gibbs sampling, and coupled with a Monte Carlo scheduling policy. Benchmark results on real-world trace data confirm that explicitly tracking dynamic state evolution improves recall predictions over static baselines and standard HLR models.

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